Process & Decision Documentation

Project/Assignment Decisions

For Side Quest 4, I designed and built a simple platformer game themed around money, titled “Make Bands Game”. The core mechanic involves navigating a white blob character across platforms to reach a money emoji, which advances the player to the next level. I focused on keeping the gameplay minimal while communicating progression through level structure, colour, and a picture of an emoji celebrating at the end. I edited both the levels.json and sketch.js files. I used JSON to control platform positions, player start points, and goal placement, while the sketch file handled game logic, screen flow, collision checks, and visuals.

Side Quest: *GenAI Documentation*

Date Used: 5 Feb 2026

Tool Disclosure: ChatGPT (GPT 5.2)

Purpose of Use: GenAI was used to help create my initial concept for a money-themed platform game within the provided p5.js structure. I used it primarily for implementation guidance, including how to structure levels using JSON, how to detect collision between the player and the money goal, and how to add start and end screens without breaking the existing game loop. I also asked for feedback on colour choices that would visually reinforce the money theme (green and gold) while maintaining readability.

Summary of Interaction: I started by explaining my idea for a game where collecting a money emoji moves the player to the next level, and asked how to implement this using the existing blob. GenAI helped clarify where to add the logic for detecting switching levels and suggested storing level positions in the JSON file. Some suggested values did not work as expected, so I manually adjusted platform positions, level order, and screen layout. I also used GenAI to explore colour options for a money-themed game and to understand how colours and images could be loaded through JSON and the sketch file. Guidance was also used to add images to the start and end screens.

Human Decision Point(s): I decided to keep the game mechanics simple (one goal per level, which is the money emoji, no enemies or scoring system) to ensure the core interaction was clear and functional. When GenAI suggestions caused layout or progression errors, I manually adjusted platform coordinates, money positions, and image placement values to achieve the intended visual and gameplay outcome. I also chose to use keyboard input (space/N) rather than clickable buttons to remain consistent with the original blob platformer interaction model.

Integrity & Verification Note: All GenAI suggestions were reviewed critically before being implemented. I manually tested each level multiple times to verify that collisions, level transitions, and screen changes worked as expected. When errors occurred, such as incorrect level order, broken transitions, or misplaced visual elements, I corrected them directly by editing the number coordinates and logic conditions rather than relying on automated fixes.

Scope of GenAI Use: GenAI supported conceptual clarification, debugging assistance, and implementation guidance. It did not generate the game concept, level designs, visual layout, final code structure, or numerical placement values. All final decisions regarding gameplay, visuals, and structure were made by me.

Limitations or Misfires: Some GenAI suggestions initially overcomplicated the project by proposing additional systems or assuming automated placement values that did not work correctly. These suggestions required simplification and manual correction to align with the assignment scope and maintain control over level design and screen layout. If you look through my chat, you will see quite a few screenshots of the AI-generated code that needed fixing.

Summary of Process (Human + Tool)

I began by outlining the concept for a money-themed platform game in point form, focusing on progression through collecting a visual goal (the money). I then mapped this idea onto the existing blob platformer structure, using JSON to define levels and goals. GenAI was used as a support tool to clarify where logic should be implemented and how data could be structured, but I manually refined all gameplay values, positions, and transitions through iterative testing. The final result reflects a balance between AI assistance and hands-on design decisions.

Decision Points & Trade-offs

Decision 1: Use JSON for level and emoji placement

- Options considered: Hardcode positions in sketch.js vs. define them in JSON
- What changed: I placed platforms, player start positions, and the money emoji in JSON
- Why: This made the game easier to scale

Decision 2: Keep mechanics minimal

- Options considered: Add enemies, timers, or amount of money gathered (score) vs. single-goal progression
- What changed: I limited gameplay to movement and single-goal progression, with reaching the money and moving onto the next level
- Why: This kept the focus on clarity, readability, and successful implementation

Verification & Judgement

I verified the project by playing through each level multiple times, ensuring the money goal triggered the correct transition, the start and end screens displayed properly, and the game did not unintentionally loop or break. I also tested different colour combinations and image placements to confirm visual clarity and thematic consistency. I verify that I made all the project ideas and final decisions.

Limitations, Dead Ends, or Open Questions

The project avoids complex mechanics to stay within the sidequest guidelines. Future improvements could include sound and more levels, but these were not required for the assignment. I also learned that even when GenAI suggestions appear to be correct, positioning and visual layout still need human judgment and testing.

Appendix

ChatGPT Chat: https://chatgpt.com/share/69856de9-df00-8003-93ad-ee74fe5a8db9

References of the images used in this Side Quest

Money_Emoji.png (used on the start screen). Source: Pinterest (original creator not identified), https://ca.pinterest.com/pin/8514686791264877/

You_Won_Emoji.png (used on the end screen). Source: Pinterest (original creator not identified), https://ca.pinterest.com/pin/662310688992339214/